proposal to construct crematoriums along the banks of the Ganga in an attempt to check unorganized cremation. The UP government also issued orders to provide up to ₹5,000 worth of financial assistance from the Namami Gange funds for each cremation.[14] Namami Gange is a flagship programme of the Modi government designed for arresting the pollution in the Ganga with the larger mission of Ganga conservation. Even Bihar announced that cremation of burial expenses of those dying due to COVID-19 would be borne by the government.[15] In addition, patrolling teams were set up along sites which saw an increase in cremations in the water or on the banks of the Ganga and its tributaries. Due to these measures, in a short period of time, there was a significant reduction in abandoned bodies in and along the river. However, despite that, the government found it difficult to maintain a balance between implementing awareness measures of stopping the jal samadhi ritual while also respecting religious sentiments.[16]

Yogi Adityanath and UP's response was singled out in attacks by the Opposition, perhaps due to the lingering sting of defeat for Rahul Gandhi, who lost his Lok Sabha seat from Amethi; a seat held by his family for decades. Even as the Tablighi episode was playing out in the media just at the onset of COVID-19 in India, *The Wire*, a left, anti-establishment online news platform, published an article about how Yogi Adityanath wanted to go ahead with a large Ram Navami celebration to take eyes off the Tablighis and wrongly attributed Acharya Paramhans's statement to the UP CM. Acharya Paramhans had quipped to the media that, 'Lord Ram would protect devotees from the coronavirus.'[17] Adityanath had issued no such statements and in fact Ayodhya's district magistrate and superintendent of police had issued a circular stating that devotees would not be allowed to gather for the event in view of the lockdown.[18] All through the pandemic, the opposition ecosystem's eyes remained trained on Adityanath. During the second wave, since there was a pouring in of cases from the NCR region into UP, Adityanath's response was particularly criticized by biased media channels frequently changing facts and digging out old photos to suit their narrative. However, in a report prepared by IIT Kanpur, which took several indicators into consideration, concluded that UP had been able to do an exceptional job in not only swiftly bringing down the COVID-19 surge during the second wave but also to keep the economy of the state stable.[19] An important achievement for the Yogi government was that it was able to